

How to Create an HR Technology Strategy and Roadmap

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By: Harsh Kundulli, Ron Hanscome, Alex Chertoff

Initiatives: Transform HR through AI; Technologies and Markets

Shifting enterprise strategy, increasing AI usage and growing complexity of the HR technology market makes aligning technology investments with critical business needs a perennial challenge for HR technology leaders. Use this research to develop an effective HR technology roadmap to drive alignment.

Insights at a Glance

Many HR technology leaders find it challenging to build a fit for purpose technology portfolio in the face of changing business requirements, AI disruption and ongoing vendor innovation. Organizations without a robust and frequently updated HR technology strategy and roadmap tend to respond reactively to a specific functional need or crisis, lacking strategic intent. An organized method for analyzing the HR technology market, contextualizing trends and developing and assessing technology options helps HR technology leaders overcome the market's complexity and volatility, and decide what technology to buy, upgrade or decommission.

HR technology leaders should follow this structured approach to creating an HR technology strategy and roadmap:

1. **Define the business outcomes** that the HR technology portfolio must produce by engaging stakeholders and, accordingly, articulate a vision and strategic guiding principles.
2. **Capture gaps and requirements** by using an HR business capability model (BCM), an HR maturity model (MM) and persona journey maps (PJMs) as tools to engage stakeholders and obtain their perspectives.
3. **Determine a best-fit future state** by analyzing the HR technology market and marrying that outside-in perspective with identified requirements to develop and assess technology portfolio options.

4. **Develop a roadmap** that captures relevant strategic, procurement, readiness, implementation and sustainment initiatives. Refresh this roadmap regularly to respond to evolving requirements.

Strategic Planning Assumption

By 2027, 75% of global midsize and large enterprises will have invested in a cloud-deployed HCM suite for administrative HR and talent management. But they will still need to use other solutions for 20% to 30% of their HR requirements.

Impact Brief

Reversing a multiyear pattern of sustained growth in HR technology investment, more than half of HR technology leaders anticipate a decrease in spend in 2026. ¹ Advances in AI continue to disrupt the HR technology market, impacting vendor capabilities, value propositions and pricing models. In this environment, it is critical that HR technology leaders optimize their technology portfolios. But, many find it challenging to build an effective strategy and roadmap that aligns HR technology investments with critical business needs, specifically around:

- Gathering and building consensus on the most important needs HR technology must meet, especially in the context of today's challenges, such as talent shortages, changing worker expectations, AI's impact on work and cost pressures.
- Analyzing the complex and ever-changing HR technology market, and assessing potential future-state technology portfolio options.

Consequently, organizations increase the risk of their HR technology portfolio falling out of sync with business needs and facing painful challenges, including:

- Siloed HR processes and disparate systems that detract from employee experience.
- Fragmented workforce data that impedes analytics and data-driven decision making.
- System redundancies, functional inefficiencies and poor adoption that reduce return on investment.
- Insufficient agility in the face of major economic, organizational and technology shifts.

Actions and Cautions

Actions

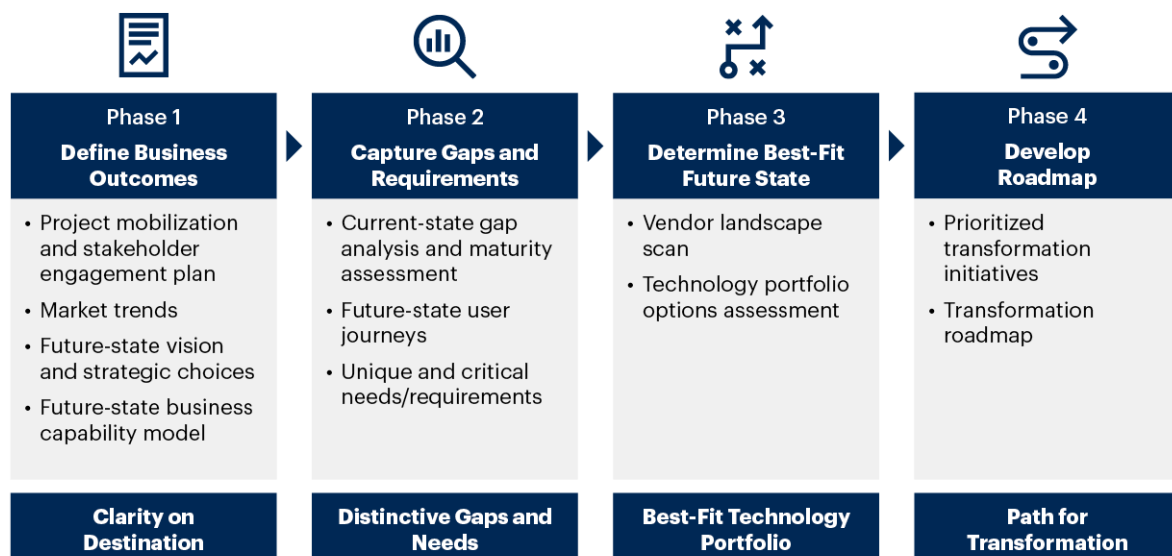
HR technology leaders should follow a structured approach to creating an HR technology strategy and roadmap (see Figure 1):

1. Define the business outcomes to clarify the desired HR technology destination.
2. Capture gaps and requirements to determine distinctive technology needs.
3. Determine a best-fit future state for the technology portfolio.
4. Develop a roadmap for the best path to technology transformation.

Figure 1: The Approach to Creating an HR Technology Strategy and Roadmap

The Approach to Creating an HR Technology Strategy and Roadmap

Outputs and Outcomes



Source: Gartner
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Gartner

How to Execute

Phase 1: Define the Business Outcomes to Be Achieved

Mobilize the Project, and Create a Stakeholder Engagement Plan

Onboard team members to work on the HR technology strategy and roadmap project and identify key stakeholders, such as the CHRO and CIO, and end users, including employees, managers and administrative users. Determine how to engage stakeholders with interviews, focus group discussions and similar sessions. Create a project plan to outline items such as scope, deliverables and timelines.

Assess Trends, Create a Target-State Vision and Align on Strategic Guiding Principles

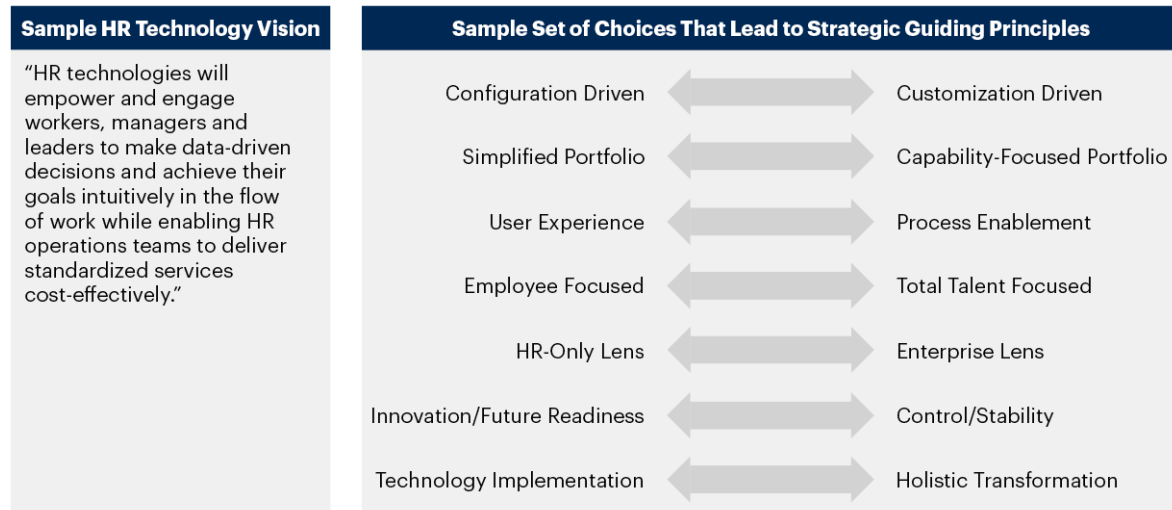
Begin by gathering and reviewing relevant strategy documents, such as business strategy and previous HR strategies, to examine the overall direction of the enterprise, major HR programs and metrics, organizational constraints and IT plans. Conduct strategic interviews with the CHRO, CIO, COO, and other leaders to align on key business and HR outcomes to achieve. Then, conduct a workshop with leaders to set the context and create an HR technology vision with strategic guiding principles. The vision should define what outcomes the organization wants the HR technology portfolio to achieve.

The strategic guiding principles will influence the inevitable trade-offs in the journey to make the HR technology portfolio fit-for-purpose. Present some choices to key stakeholders to generate debate.

Discuss the implications of these choices and help stakeholders come to a consensus on which side of the spectrum they want to land, then convert these choices into strategic guiding principles. See Figure 2 for a sample set of the choices that can be used to create the guiding principles.

Figure 2: Sample HR Technology Vision and Choices That Lead to Strategic Guiding Principles

Sample HR Technology Vision and Choices That Lead to Strategic Guiding Principles



Source: Gartner
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Gartner

Develop the Future-State HR Business Capability Model

In the meantime, develop a future-state HR business capability model (BCM). An HR BCM logically groups the HR business capabilities an organization needs to execute its business model. It allows stakeholders to see a common view of HR business capabilities that is independent of organizational structure, processes, people or technologies.

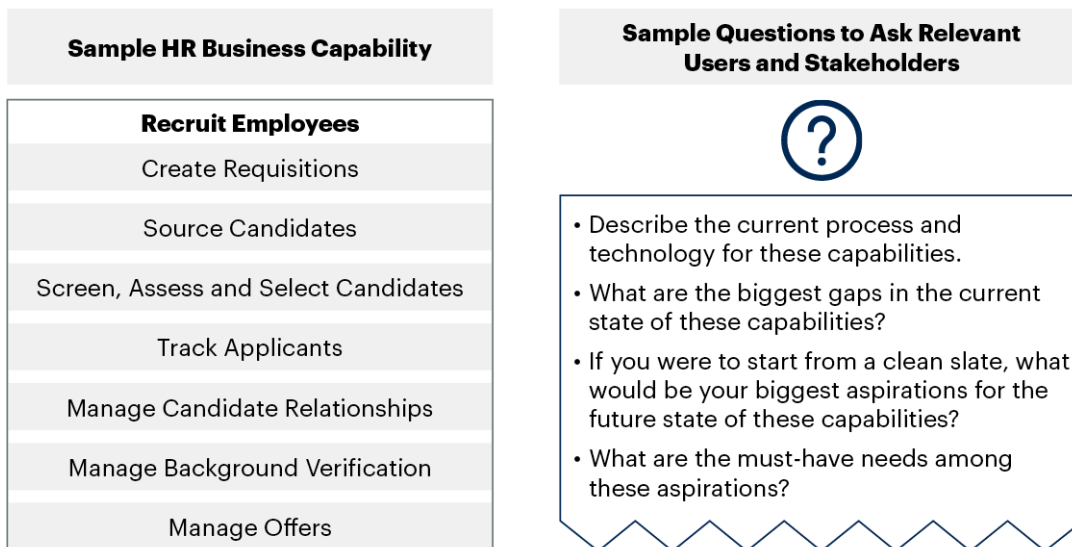
Phase 2: Assess the Current State and Capture Requirements

Assess the Current State Using the HR BCM

Conduct discovery workshops with end users and stakeholders to assess the current state and understand requirements. Use the HR BCM to elicit requirements from users (see Figure 3).

Figure 3: Sample Discovery Workshop Questions

Sample Discovery Workshop Questions



Source: Gartner
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Gartner

During these discovery workshops, share leading practices in the market. Convert needs to technology requirements. Focus only on distinctive requirements (DRs): those that are unique to the organization or highly critical to achieve business outcomes. The insights from these workshops, interviews and document reviews should also allow you to create a current-state blueprint of the HR technology portfolio. A well-made blueprint should show all the HR technologies in the portfolio, the HR capabilities they enable, potential inefficiencies (e.g., multiple technologies enabling the same capability) and integration gaps.

Identify User Experience Requirements

Persona journey maps (PJM) capture experience requirements that often straddle HR business capabilities. First, create a list of relevant user personas, including employees, managers, leaders, HR and IT administrators, contingent workers, and even candidates or alumni. Conduct surveys, interviews and focus groups with relevant user groups to create personas and identify journeys that matter to them. Then, conduct a gap analysis to identify the largest deltas between the current and desired future states. This exercise will help prioritize HR business capabilities for transformation. Use Gartner's [HR Score](#) tool to plot the current-state and desired future-state maturities, and identify gaps to prioritize.

Phase 3: Determine the Best-Fit Future-State Technology Portfolio

Examine the Vendor Landscape, and Develop and Assess Technology Portfolio Options

Research relevant HR technology vendors, including HCM suites and point solutions. Create a list of relevant vendors, determine their strengths and weaknesses, and understand gaps and product roadmaps. Use this high-level knowledge of the vendor landscape to determine which technology levers — the HCM suite, HCM suite extensions and point solutions — could meet which DRs in which HR business capabilities.

This analysis should provide a firm basis for developing the future-state technology portfolio options. Then, conduct a workshop with key stakeholders to evaluate each option on the following parameters, and choose the best-fit one:

- Ability to realize the future-state vision
- Alignment with strategic guiding principles
- Ability to meet DRs within high-priority HR business capabilities
- Viability, maturity and roadmap quality of the vendors under consideration
- Rough order-of-magnitude cost (you may ask for high-level preliminary quotes from your prospective vendors and system implementation partners)
- Risks (e.g., change risk, data migration risk, schedule risk, resource risk, integration risk)

Phase 4: Chart a Path to the Desired Future State

Identify and Prioritize Transformation Roadmap Initiatives

With a strong strategic foundation in place, create or update your three-year HR technology roadmap.

Use the log of current-state pain points and aspirations as the starting point to identify opportunities for transformation. Convert these opportunities into roadmap initiatives with descriptions, time frames and owners. These initiatives should reflect the chosen technology option (e.g., if the chosen option involves heavy reliance on point solutions, list a point solution strategy project).

Then, conduct a workshop with stakeholders to prioritize these initiatives based on the following criteria:

- **Nature of the initiative** — Some initiatives should happen before others. For example, you must complete readiness initiatives, such as job architecture optimization and change management planning, before you implement the technology.
- **Value of the initiative** — Measure value using the initiative's ability to achieve the vision, align with the strategic guiding principles and contribute toward meeting the DRs within high-priority HR business capabilities.
- **Complexity** — The higher the extent of resources required, the level of stakeholder involvement and the extent of dependencies, the higher the complexity.
- **Time to value** — Estimate the time between the initial investment and value creation. Prioritize quick wins that produce high value with relatively low complexity and short time to value.
- **Cost** — Estimate the cost to complete the initiative. Use an internal procurement tool or an external evaluation tool to guide you through technology evaluations and help estimate typical costs. The [Gartner BuySmart™](#) tool helps guide you through technology evaluations with templates containing requirements and scorecards to help select the best providers for your needs. Using a connected workflow, BuySmart enables you to conduct thorough evaluations to invest confidently. For example, see the BuySmart templates designed for [HCM Suites for 1,000+ Employee Enterprises](#) and [Voice of the Employee Solutions](#).

Create an HR Technology Transformation Roadmap

Incorporate your level of organizational readiness while planning how to stage your transformation. Based on the initiative prioritization and transformation staging considerations, position initiatives appropriately on the draft transformation roadmap. These initiatives could be:

- Quick wins (e.g., quick-fix process improvements, **robotic process automation**)
- Strategic initiatives (e.g., domain strategy, data strategy)
- Business transformation initiatives (e.g., operating model design, change management)
- Technology initiatives (e.g., implementation planning and delivery, decommissioning)

Create a strategy governance model that includes regular steering committee meetings (recommended quarterly, but at a minimum twice a year). These meetings should assess progress against the strategy and roadmap and the business case. Adopting a structured approach to creating and refreshing your HR technology strategy and roadmap will ensure that your HR technology investments are in line with changing business and environmental realities and help drive optimal adoption.

Success Measures

HR technology leaders can measure the success of their HR technology strategy and roadmap across the following categories:

- **Cost and ROI** — Total cost of ownership for the HR technology portfolio, budget adherence and cost per employee benchmarked against industry norms
- **Business outcome achievement** — Employee experience, productivity and agility
- **Technology adoption and utilization** — System adoption rates and NPS
- **Alignment and governance** — Compliance with guiding principles and frequency of roadmap updates
- **Operational efficiency** — Reduction in manual processes and time saved through automation

Evidence

¹ **2025 Gartner HR Technology Leader Survey.** This survey was conducted to understand the structure, effectiveness, outcomes, collaboration, and future needs of HR technology teams and solutions within organizations. The research was conducted online in two waves from 4 June to 7 August and 29 October to 11 November among 42 HR technology leaders from different geographies and industries. The survey was designed and developed by Gartner's HR practice research team. Disclaimer: The results of this survey do not represent global findings or the market as a whole, but reflect the sentiments of the respondents and companies surveyed.

Document Revision History

[How to Create an HR Technology Strategy and Roadmap - 28 February 2023](#)

Recommended by the Authors

Some documents may not be available as part of your current Gartner subscription.

[Develop a Strategic HR Technology Roadmap](#)

[2024-2026 Strategic Roadmap for HR Technology Investments](#)

[Tool: HR Technology Market Taxonomy](#)

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